

Getting Started

This checklist helps you confirm that a freshly installed SkillBridge instance is healthy before you invite instructors and students. It assumes you have already run the installer (`./install.sh`) or followed the manual setup steps from the installation guide.

1. Confirm prerequisites

1. **Docker & Compose** – run `docker compose version` (or `docker-compose version`) and confirm both client and server report compatible versions.
2. **Node.js 18+** – `node -v` should return `18.x` or newer if you plan to run any scripts outside Docker.
3. **Database access** – if PostgreSQL or Redis live on managed services, make sure firewall rules allow traffic from the application hosts.

 **Tip:** The installer fails fast when a prerequisite is missing. Rerun `./install.sh` after fixing the requirement to confirm every check passes.

2. Start the stack

If you are using Docker Compose:

```
docker compose up -d --build
```

For manual installs (without Docker):

```
npm --prefix backend install
npm --prefix backend run migrate
npm --prefix backend run seed      # optional sample data
npm --prefix backend run start     # or pm2 start backend

npm --prefix frontend install
npm --prefix frontend run build
npm --prefix frontend run start    # or next dev for local debugging
```

Wait until the backend reports `Server listening on PORT 5002` (or your custom port) before proceeding.

3. Create or verify admin access

During installation the script prompts for an initial admin email and password. If you skipped that step or need a new administrator:

```
docker compose exec backend node scripts/create-admin.js \
  --email admin@example.com \
  --password "S3curePass!"
```

Replace the command with your preferred credentials. For manual installs run the script from the repository root without `docker compose exec` .

4. Smoke test the platform

Run these checks to ensure the critical paths work:

- Visit `http://localhost:3000` (or your domain) and confirm the landing page renders without console errors.

- Sign in as the admin account and browse to `/dashboard/admin` . Verify that navigation, search, and basic analytics load.
- Open the API health check (`http://localhost:5002/api/health`) and confirm it returns `{"status": "ok"}` .
- Trigger a password reset email to confirm SMTP credentials are valid.
- Upload a logo at `/dashboard/admin/settings/app` to make sure the backend can write to `backend/uploads/app` .

5. Next steps

- Review the [configuration reference](#) to lock down environment variables for production.
- Follow the [deployment guide](#) for TLS, CORS, and scaling advice.
- Invite another teammate so more than one person can access the admin panel.

Once these checks pass you have a working baseline. Continue with the workflow guides to configure courses, payments, and marketing content.